

What else to watch: *The Man with the Rubber Head* (1901) ■ *A Trip to Mars* (1910) ■ *Metropolis* (1927, pp.32–33) ■ *The Invisible Man* (1933) ■ *First Men in the Moon* (1964) ■ *Hugo* (2011)

Méliès's short movies were simply entertainments, created for the sensation seekers who roamed the boulevards of *fin-de-siècle* Paris. Filled with chorus girls, ghosts, and Mephistophelian devils, the movies started out as recordings of simple magic acts and evolved into fanciful stories realized through innovative and audacious camera trickery—cinema's fledgling special effects. By 1902, Méliès was ready to pull off his biggest illusion: to take his audiences to the moon and back.

Sci-fi and satire

A Trip to the Moon was the first movie to be inspired by the popular "scientific romances" of Jules Verne and H. G. Wells, and is widely acknowledged as the world's first science-fiction movie. But while it is true that Méliès conjured up the basic iconography of sci-fi cinema—the sleek rocket ship, the moon hurtling toward the camera, and the little green men—the director did not set out to invent a genre. His aim was to present a mischievous satire of Victorian values, a boisterous comedy lampooning the reckless industrial revolutionaries of Western Europe.

In Méliès's hands, men of science are destructive fools. Led by Professor Barbenfouillis (played by Méliès himself), they squabble and jump

When they reach the moon, the scientists discover a strange land. Their arrogant attitude toward the moon people has led the movie to be seen as an anti-imperialist satire.



Georges Méliès Director

Méliès's early short movies experimented with the theatrical

techniques and special effects he had mastered as a stage magician. He used the camera to make people and objects disappear, reappear, or transform completely, and devised countless technical

innovations. Méliès wrote, directed, and starred in more than 500 motion pictures, pioneering the genres of science fiction, horror, and suspense.

Key movies

1896 *The Devil's Castle*
1902 *A Trip to the Moon*
1904 *Whirling the Worlds*
1912 *The Conquest of the Pole*

up and down like unruly children, and when they land on the lunar surface, their rocket stabs the Man in the Moon in his eye. They cause chaos in the kingdom of the Selenites—whom they treat as mindless savages—and they only make it home by accident. A statue of Barbenfouillis appears in the final scene—a caricature of

a pompous old man, resembling one of Méliès's political cartoons. Its inscription reads "*Labor omnia vincit*" (Work conquers all), which, in light of the chaos that has preceded it, takes on a decidedly ironic tone. ■

